



Logistical grind: From airline hassles to Customs delays (**pics, above**), Tejaswin's toughest vault often comes before the runway — just getting his poles there. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

transport his poles by train, tucking them alongside the overhead fans in the sleeper compartment. That, though, is not an option when he flies.

"The first challenge is to get it past the CISF guards at the entry gates. The moment they see them, they say I can't go inside. I'll have to explain I'm an athlete and I've travelled with these things before. While they are making up their minds, there will be a bunch of passengers all staring at me thinking I'm carrying a weapon or something," says Tejaswin.

Once inside, he still has to get the poles through the baggage counter. "Usually your javelins and those sorts of things can be accommodated in that big belt, but the pole vault poles cannot," he says.

All baggage at Delhi's Terminal 3 is transferred through two cargo lifts

— neither of which can fit a 16-foot-long pole. A special lift has to be used instead.

Tejaswin discovered this the hard way when he first brought his poles from the USA, where he competed for Kansas State University in the NCAA. "The first time I came with my poles, I had a layover in Finland, and when I reached Delhi, I found that my poles hadn't come on the plane. When they did get to India on a subsequent flight, I was told that even though they had taken the poles out of the plane, they didn't know how to get it through the airport and that they were just going to send it back to Finland. That's when I had to ring up everyone I knew in Indian sport. Finally, after nearly four days, one person told me that there is a third way of getting oversized baggage out of a plane — and that was through a location known as the 'steel gate'."

Accessing the gate is complicated for a reason. "I found out later that apart from me, the only time that steel gate is used is when the airlines are transporting catering, or when the Prime Minister is travelling. So

my poles are a bit special!"

That same gate is used when Tejaswin flies out of the country with his poles. "First, I have to get a letter written by the airline to allow me to use that gate. At check-in, the first thing they say is it can't be done because it's such a huge hassle, so I always carry a copy of every letter I've had made out in the past. In the letter, the airline writes that they've accepted my baggage and that it can't go through the two regular cargo lifts. The first time I got the letter made, they called it a 'pole bolt', and now every time I get a letter made, it says 'pole bolt'."

That letter is addressed to the CISF commandant, the head of security, and the head of customs, requesting permission to use the special gate. "I have to go and get the letter signed by all of them. This also takes time because it's hard to catch all of them. Someone is on his rounds, someone else might be having tea."

Eventually, the doors to that special cargo lift — about 15 feet high and 20 feet long, by Tejaswin's reckoning — open, and the poles go